The aircraft touched down at Tezpur Air Force Station at 5 p.m. The Eastern Army Commander, Lieutenant General Bogey Sen, and his BGS, Brigadier H. K. Sibal, met General Thapar at the aircraft bay. Both the officers were looking extremely grim. Sen informed Thapar that the Chinese had that morning started their main offensive against Se-la and had attacked 4 Garhwal's forward positions during the day. In fact, even as they spoke, Sen said, the fighting was going on in Se-la.

Thapar decided to stay in Tezpur. He sent a wireless message to Kaul ordering the corps commander to return at once to Tezpur. As the party headed for Corps HQ, Sen filled Thapar in on the details of the events of the morning. The latest information from 4 Division HQ was that the GOC, Pathania, had ordered the battalion to break contact and fall back towards Se-la Top.

Palit, sitting in the front seat of the staff car, thought he had misheard the army commander. Since the chief said nothing, Palit asked Sen: 'Why were they withdrawn? If the Garhwalis had repulsed four attacks by the Chinese surely they should remain at their post?'

Sen was obviously annoyed with the DMO's interjection. He replied sullenly that if Palit wanted an answer to his question he would have to ask GOC 4 Division himself.

Palit, the main architect of 62 Infantry Brigade digging in at Se-la, was not going to be put off. He pointed out to Thapar and Sen the absurdity of the order. If the Garhwalis were to break off contact and pull back, it would leave the main defences unguarded and allow the assaulting Chinese troops to regroup, build up without interference and then launch an assault at points of their own choosing.

Thapar still did not react; he seemed preoccupied and distant, gazing absently at the tea gardens they were speeding past. 'You have to issue immediate orders to cancel the withdrawal of the covering troops,' implored Palit, twisting to look at Sen at the back of the car.

'It is not for me to interfere in IV Corps' battles,' Sen replied coldly.

'Not even in the absence of the corps commander?' As a junior officer, Palit was sticking his neck out, but Sen just ignored his question. Thapar still said nothing. By then the staff car had pulled up outside the IV Corps HQ. It was now completely dark outside.

In the absence of Kaul, BGS IV Corps, Brigadier K. K. Singh, received the chief. Without any preamble, the party proceeded towards the corps's